

THE LEDGER

The payments followed a pattern Watson had noticed but never proved. Each victim had trusted the same polished settlement process before fear closed around them.

A survivor supplied the next lead: the computer used during payment. Lestrade recovered it before anyone could alter what remained.



The settlement client looked ordinary and had completed the task its owner expected. Holmes was interested in what happened beyond the screen.

The machine was sealed for examination. Investigators had to establish what the client had really done and whether it could lead them deeper into the operation.



Analysis turned suspicion into proof. The settlement client had performed a second task while presenting something harmless to its owner.

Payment was only the visible layer. Private material had moved outward, and a concealed instruction showed that the victims belonged to one deliberate operation.



The recovered data also carried a physical lead, buried where an ordinary user would never see it. Holmes sent the result to Lestrade without repeating it aloud.

Mycroft recognized the style of the message. Someone wanted Holmes to understand that the machinery had an author.



SILVERTOWN

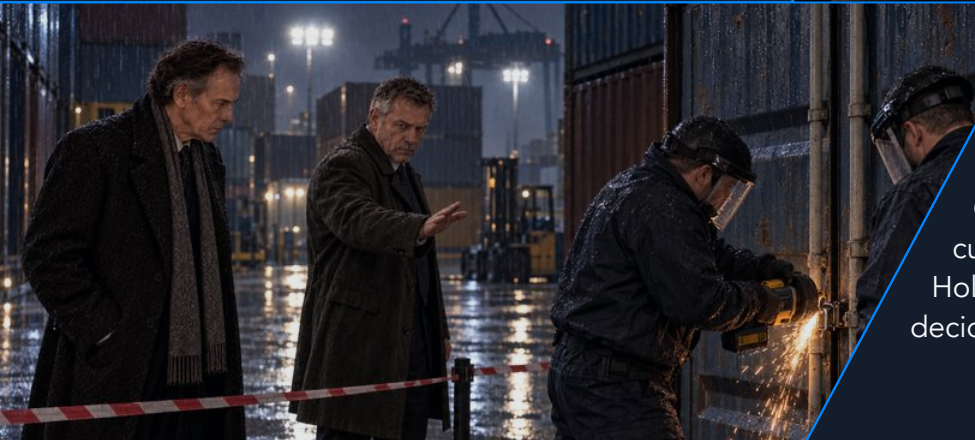
The recovered lead pointed east toward the Silvertown container yards. Lestrade moved before the paperwork could slow him.

The drive passed through rain and industrial light. Every minute felt like a decision someone else had already made.



The Silvertown yard smelled of river water, rust, and diesel. Police lights moved between rows of stacked steel.

One container stood locked and silent. A cutter screamed through the metal while Holmes waited beyond the door, refusing to decide what lay inside.



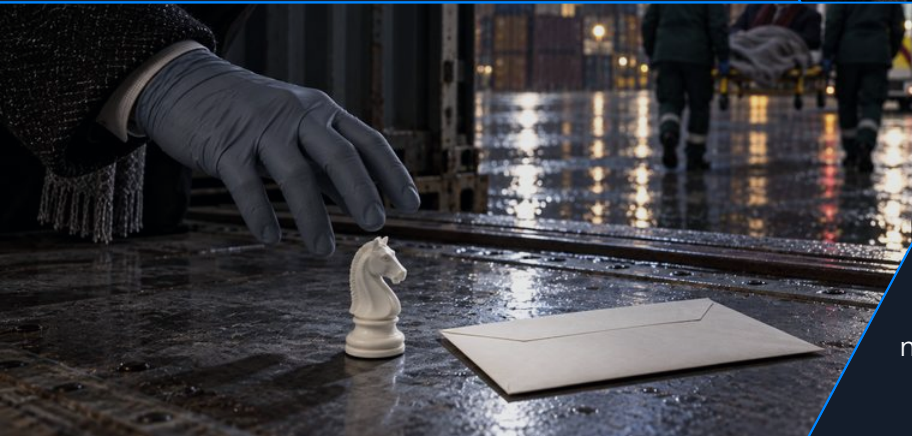
Inside they found Watson alive, cold, weak, and angry enough to be himself. Holmes stood close enough to hear every breath.

Watson remembered a chair and a voice through a speaker. Once, the frightened guard had spoken to someone he clearly considered his superior.



Whoever had guarded Watson fled minutes before police arrived, leaving a powered laptop beside the chair.

Near Watson lay a white knight and a sealed envelope. Holmes touched neither until Watson was safe. The note welcomed him back and mocked his retirement. It needed no signature.



THE VOICES BEHIND THE NAMES

Watson survived. For a few hours, that was enough. Then the objects left at Silvertown began to speak.

The abandoned laptop showed a hurried attempt to erase recent activity. One communications client remained, but its account, server, and purpose were still unknown.



The machine was sealed for examination. The task was simple to state and difficult to prove.

Investigators had to recover what survived the wiping attempt and determine how the laptop connected its unknown operator to the wider operation.



POST-SOLVE CONTENT HIDDEN
REVEAL AFTER SHERLOCK